

CHAPTER FOUR

The Inner Critic at Seventeen

— Priya —

I am writing this in my journal because Ms. Calloway said one of the things we are going to do this year is say things straight to ourselves on paper, and I am not sure I have ever fully done that. Lists, yes. Lists I have done since I was seven. But lists are how I avoid saying things straight. The list is a thing I can hand to myself in pieces. A paragraph is a thing I have to commit to.

Okay. I am committing.

The Inner Critic is still here.

I have been doing the work since I was nine. I caught her, named her, called her loud-not-true, carried Ms. Calloway's index card around for three years. The card is in a drawer now. I have not had to look at it in maybe four years.

But she is still here.

She is quieter than she used to be. She does not run my mornings anymore. She does not run my homework. She does not run my conversations with Hannah. But she still shows up — usually when I am tired, usually in the half hour before I fall asleep, usually when something has gone wrong and I am trying to figure out who is at fault and have a habit, that I have not entirely broken, of assuming it is me. This week she has been showing up about college applications. Here is the thing about college applications, when you are the kid I have been.

You are supposed to write an essay that distills you down to about six hundred and fifty words. You are supposed to make those words feel both authentic and impressive. You are supposed to be specific but not weird. You are supposed to be vulnerable but not too vulnerable. You are supposed to be funny but not as funny as Jordan. You are supposed to be smart but not in a way that sounds smug. The list of contradictions goes on for paragraphs.

The Inner Critic has, all month, been telling me that whatever I write is wrong.

Draft one was — she said — too earnest. Draft two was — she said — too performative. Draft three was — she said — actually good, but only because I have copied the shape of an essay I read on a college's website, and the admissions officer would see through it immediately. Draft four was — she said — fine, but did I really want to write about that. Draft five — she said — was the wrong topic entirely. I should be writing about my Indian heritage. Or, she said, I should not be writing about my Indian heritage because that is the obvious thing and the obvious thing is the lazy thing.

I have been listening to her, against my better judgment, for three weeks.

This morning I told Hannah about it. We were walking from third period to fourth period. I said Hannah I have rewritten my Common App essay six times.

Hannah, who has known me since third grade and who is the most patient human being I have ever met, said Priya. Stop. Show me the drafts.

I sent her the drafts on Google Docs at lunch.

She read all six drafts in maybe forty minutes during fifth period, which is study hall for both of us. At the end of fifth period she found me in the hallway and said:

Priya. The third one is the best. Use the third one. Stop rewriting it. You are doing the thing.

I said what thing.

She said the thing where the Inner Critic is dressed up as your editor. I stopped walking.

Hannah does not, generally, name the Inner Critic out loud. She knows about it because we have been friends for ten years and she has heard me talk about it. She does not usually use the name herself. The fact that she used the name today — in the hallway, between fifth and sixth period — meant she was, in some small way, calling me out. Saying Priya, you are in a known pattern. I see it.

I started walking again.

I said you are right.

She said I know.

I said I am going to submit the third draft.

She said good.

We went to sixth period.

That was — and this is the part I want to write down — that was the fastest the Inner Critic has ever been interrupted by an outside person in my life. Usually I am the one who has to catch her. Usually I have to do the catching alone, in my head, with sentences I have been practicing since I was nine. Today Hannah caught her for me, in three sentences, in a hallway.

I think — and I want to say this carefully because it feels important — I think one of the gifts of having had a cohort like ours is that the catching the Inner Critic work has become distributed. It is not just my work anymore. It is the cohort's work. Hannah can catch mine. I can catch Hannah's. Sofia can catch almost anybody's. Marcus can catch Jordan's. Theo, who notices everything, can catch all of ours when we have not even noticed she is there yet.

I have been thinking of the Inner Coach as a voice inside me. What if the Inner Coach has, all along, also been the voices of other people who know me well enough to say Priya, that is the Critic. That is not you. Stop.

What if the Inner Coach is — partly, maybe — the cohort.

I am not saying this to be cute. I am saying it because I think it is real. I have spent eight years trying to make my Inner Coach louder than my Inner Critic. I have made her louder. But she is not as loud as the Critic in the moments when I am tired. The Critic is older. The Critic has more practice. The Critic was there first.

But Hannah's voice — and Sofia's voice, and Ms. Calloway's voice, and Marcus's voice when he tells me I am being too hard on myself, which he does about once a month — those voices, added together, are louder than the Critic. The cohort's collective voice, when it is around me, can shut the Critic up faster than my own coaching can.

This is going to be a problem when we leave.

Most of us are going to different schools. I am going to be in Boston, probably, if I get in to the school I am applying to. Hannah is going to be in California. Sofia might be in Chicago. Marcus is staying close, at the state university an hour away. Jordan is taking a year — staying home, working at the bookstore, writing. Amara is going east. Theo is going east. Maya is staying close, art school. Darius is staying close. Kezia is

staying close — community college nursing pathway, then transfer. We are scattering.

The cohort that catches my Critic in hallways is not going to be in my hallways anymore.

I have been thinking about this since August. I have not, until tonight, written it down. The Inner Critic, of course, used

my anxiety about leaving the cohort as another thing to attack me with — Priya, you cannot function without other people, you have been propped up by friends for ten years, when you are alone you will fall apart, you are weaker than you think.

That is, I now realize, also her dressed up as my editor.

The truth is: I have been practicing, with the cohort, for ten years. Practicing catching the Critic. Practicing not believing her. Practicing saying it out loud. The cohort is leaving but the practice is in me. I have been the one doing the practice. The cohort has been my training ground. When I am alone in a dorm in Boston next September, the Critic will show up. She will. I am not going to pretend she won't. She will show up at 11 p.m. on the Sunday before a paper is due and she will tell me I am not smart enough to be at the school I am at. She will tell me that the kids around me are real and I am performing. She will tell me that my Common App essay was a fraud and they let me in because they had to fill a quota.

She will try.

And I will — at eighteen, alone in a dorm room — do what I have been training for ten years to do. I will catch her. I will name her. I will say that is the Critic. That is not me. That is not true. That is just loud. I will write Hannah a text and Hannah will write back from California, in a different time zone, and Hannah will be a smaller-but-real version of the catching she did for me in the hallway today.

The cohort is not going to be in my hallway. But the cohort is going to be in my phone. And the practice is going to be in my body. And the Inner Coach is going to be — for the first time in my life — fully mine, because she has to be.

That is going to be okay.

I am eighteen — almost eighteen — and the Inner Critic is going to be with me for the rest of my life. We had a whole

lesson about this in third grade. Ms. Calloway told us, when we were nine, that the Critic does not

go away. She told us our job was not to get rid of her. Our job was to get faster at catching her.

I have gotten faster.

The first time I caught her, I needed a bathroom stall and twenty minutes and a meeting with Ms. Calloway. I was nine.

Today I needed a hallway and three sentences from Hannah. I am seventeen.

By the time I am thirty, I might catch her — most of the time — before she even finishes her first sentence. Maybe I will be too quick for her by then. Maybe she will give up showing up at all, except occasionally, on bad weeks.

That is the practice.

That is what I have been doing.

I am submitting the third draft of my essay tonight. Hannah is right. The third draft is good. The third draft is me.

I am Priya. I am tired. I am still smart. I am still the kid who notices. I am the kid who has been making lists for eleven years because lists are how my brain holds the world together, and that is fine, lists are a tool, and Ms. Calloway told me so in fourth grade.

I am going to Boston. Probably. If they take me.

If they do not take me, I will go somewhere else, and somewhere else will be fine.

The Critic, tonight, is whispering that they will not take me. The Critic, tonight, is loud, not true.

I am closing this journal.

I am submitting the essay.

I am going to sleep.

— Priya